

Hippos: The River Giants

Hippos, short for *Hippopotamus amphibius*, are large, mostly herbivorous mammals native to sub-Saharan Africa. Despite their stocky build and short legs, they are one of the most dangerous animals in Africa due to their territorial nature and powerful jaws. Adult males can weigh up to 3,500 kg (7,700 pounds), making them the third-largest land mammal after elephants and white rhinos.

Hippos spend most of their time submerged in rivers and lakes to keep their massive bodies cool under the hot African sun. Their eyes, ears, and nostrils are located on the top of their heads, allowing them to see and breathe while mostly underwater. At night, they leave the water to graze on grasses, often traveling several kilometers in search of food.

Though they resemble pigs, hippos are more closely related to whales and dolphins. They communicate through grunts, bellows, and even underwater "clicks" that are still being studied by scientists.

Hippos play an important role in their ecosystems, helping to shape river environments and support biodiversity. However, they are currently classified as vulnerable due to habitat loss and illegal hunting for their ivory-like teeth.